

ON TECHNIQUE

Melody and harmony

The great purity of the interweaving melodic lines in the music of the Renaissance composer Palestrina was a quality greatly admired by Bruckner. In his Mass in E minor, commissioned for the inauguration of the Votive Chapel of the New Cathedral in Linz (which remained unfinished until 1924), the music recalls Palestrina's spiritual polyphony. Yet Bruckner was also influenced by the radical harmony of Wagner—tense, chromatic, exploratory, ambiguous, unstable, complex—which pushed the limits of convention. Bruckner found a way of drawing both elements together in a style that was entirely his own.

Mastery and misconception

When Sechter died in 1867, Bruckner was asked to apply to replace him as a professor at the Vienna Conservatory. After chronic indecision, he finally accepted the post, and gained a reputation as a fine teacher whose brand of unpretentious eccentricity was understood and (once they were used to it) generally liked by his pupils. Bruckner then began to appear more widely as an organist: the magnificence of his improvisations, for example at Paris's Notre-Dame in 1869 and at London's Royal Albert Hall two years later, quickly passed into legend.

Bruckner was gradually developing into one of the greatest symphonists that classical music had ever known; his work introduced new aspects of depth, originality, grandeur, and audaciousness into the symphonic form. His official First